tral to be named after Dr Ambedkar. While working on the draft of the Constitution, Babasaheb used to take a train to Delhi from the station," explains former minister and RPI leader Avinash Mahatekar. He also wants Dadar station to be renamed 'Chaityabhoomi' after the Ambedkar memorial located nearby. The Maharashtra assembly had in 2020 approved a resolution for Mumbai Central to be named after philanthropist Jagannath 'Nana' Shankarsheth, who played a seminal role in the development of Bombay in the colonial era.

Maratha groups like the Sambhaji Brigade have also sought that Maharashtra's 'cultural capital' Pune be renamed 'Jijaunagar'—after Rajmata Jijabai, mother of Shivaji, for her role in resettling the city in the 17th century after it was razed by the Adilshahi general Murar Jagdeo.

These competing demands now have the government on the back foot. For instance, the MVA regime had to change its decision to name the greenfield Navi Mumbai international airport after Bal Thackeray. In August 2022, the state legislature approved the motion to name the airport after D.B. Patil, a former Lok Sabha MP of the Peasants and Workers Party (PWP) for his yeoman work in getting remunerative compensation for the local peasant communities like the Aagaris whose lands were acquired for the development of the satellite city of Navi Mumbai in the 1970s.

Writer-activist Sanjay Sonawani treats the renaming fetish with an air of tired bemusement. "The main factors are caste pride and identity and the Hindu versus Muslim narrative. Unfortunately, people do not know where their interests lie... religious and caste identities are getting sharpened, leading to the demands getting an aggressive edge," he says. For activists like him, the SC's comments on the issue will have come as a salve. While disposing of Upadhyay's petition, the court said, "The history of any nation cannot haunt the present and future generations of a nation to the point that succeeding generations become prisoners of the past... What are you trying to achieve here? Do you want to keep the country on the boil?" It remains to be seen what ripples the obiter dicta will create in Maharashtra and other states prone to the renaming bug. ■



SHOOT TO KILL
Video grab of the Umesh Pal killing; Atiq Ahmed

UTTAR PRADESH/ LAW

BULLDOZING JUSTICE

By Prashant Srivastava

Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath revels in the 'Bulldozer baba' image he has built for himself, but the events of the past couple of weeks will have knocked it down a few notches. The fortnight saw two high-profile cases where three people were killed, which has led to people questioning the Yogi narrative—of him being the tough, straight-shooting marshal who cleaned up a bad town, so to speak.

In the first case, 46-year-old Pramila Dixit and her daughter Neha, 22, were killed during an anti-encroachment "bulldozer action" on February 13. In the second, Umesh Pal, the prime witness in the 2005 murder case of Bahujan Samaj Party MLA Raju Pal, was shot dead outside his house in Prayagraj on February 24. Two of the five UP policemen in his security detail were also killed. Later, Arbaaz, the alleged driver for the assailants, was killed in a police encounter. Jailed don-turned-neta Atiq Ahmed and his associates are the prime suspects in the case. The UP Police have filed an FIR against Atiq, his wife Shaista Praveen, his brother Khalid Azim, two of his sons, and several others.

The Prayagraj Development Authority also brought out the bulldozers, demolishing the property of local journalist Zafar Ahmed, who they initially claimed was Atiq's relative. Shaista and two of her minor sons were living here on rent after Atiq's own residence was demolished in September 2020.

Yogi's 'tough on crime' narrative has taken a beating in the past few weeks